Creo Advisors

Competitive Benchmark

The Summer Group (Craig Group) · Rick Williams / *Create the Future* · Quadrillion Partners

ENT 105 — Creo Advisors team

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One-paragraph thesis. The three names Creo asked us to benchmark are not three versions of the same competitor; they are three *archetypes* of how a small advisory brand reaches senior buyers. **Craig Group** (the firm we believe is meant by "The Summer Group") is a PE-exclusive go-to-market boutique that wins on a razor-sharp niche, trademarked products timed to the deal cycle, and founder-led association networking. **Rick Williams** is a one-person thought-leadership brand that wins on a single trademarked idea, an email list he claims at 50,000 readers, and relentless repurposing of each piece of writing across newsletter, bylines, podcast, and keynotes. **Quadrillion Partners** is an operator-led boutique that wins on quotable anti-consultant positioning, a catalog of eight named, priced, outcome-ranged sprints, and a coordinated book-launch content stack. None of the three has what Creo's brief asks for — a sustained engine that puts a message in front of 2,000+ decision makers every 8–12 weeks — and each has a visible gap Creo can occupy. The practical conclusion: **copy the mechanics (named offers, email-first capture, founder-as-channel, sequenced launches), avoid the failure modes (bursty cadence, unaudited reach claims, hero-dependence, inconsistent numbers), and differentiate on the three things none of them can show: a named team, attributed proof, and a cadence that actually holds.**

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1 Purpose, Scope, and an Identification Note

1.1 Why these three

Creo's project brief asks the team to sharpen the firm's value proposition, segment its buyers, and build a "scalable, repeatable digital marketing engine" with a message in front of 2,000+ decision makers every 8–12 weeks. The client then named three benchmarks. We read that list as a request to answer four questions for each:

1. **What do they sell, to whom, and how is it packaged?** (positioning, productization, pricing signals)
2. **What proof do they show?** (and how much of it is verifiable)
3. **How does their marketing engine actually run?** (channel by channel, with cadence and audience-size evidence)
4. **What should Creo copy, avoid, or position against?**

Everything here comes from public sources read on 19–20 October 2026 (firm websites, LinkedIn, press wires, podcast directories, publisher pages, company registries). Figures are tagged *(self-reported)* where only the firm asserts them. Items we could not confirm are listed in §8 rather than silently dropped.

1.2 "The Summer Group" — who we think is meant [Medium confidence]

No advisory firm named "The Summer Group" exists in the PE value-creation, strategy, or growth-consulting space. Searches on the exact name and its variants (Summer Group, Summers Group, Sommer Group, Summus Group) surfaced only an insurance agency in La Habra, California, an executive-search firm, a Buffalo PE investor (Summer Street Capital), a real-estate diligence shop, and a fintech consultancy. None is a plausible benchmark for Creo. The best match is **Craig Group** (`https://www.craiggroup.io`), founded in 2019 by **Summer Craig** in Houston, Texas. Its legal entity is *Summer Craig Consulting LLC*, its original LinkedIn handle was `/company/summer-craig-consulting/`, and it sells revenue-growth advisory exclusively to PE-backed lower-middle-market companies — exactly the peer a Creo partner would hear described as "Summer's group" at an ACG event. We benchmark Craig Group below at roughly 75% confidence and **recommend Creo confirm the name at the next weekly check-in** before this section is cited in the final plan.

1.3 Three archetypes, not three look-alikes

Benchmark	Archetype	What it is really a benchmark *for*
Craig Group	PE-exclusive functional boutique	Niche discipline, deal-cycle-timed productized diagnostics, association embedding, PR habit
Rick Williams	Personal thought-leadership brand	Email-first audience building, one owned framework, write-once/publish-everywhere repurposing
Quadrillion Partners	Operator-led productized boutique	Quotable anti-consultant positioning, named/priced sprint catalog, sequenced book-launch stack

2 Benchmark at a Glance

	Craig Group	Rick Williams	Quadrillion Partners	Creo today
HQ / founded	Houston TX, 2019	Boston/Medford MA, LLC (date n/a); book 2024	Plano (Dallas) TX, 2012	Pembroke MA, 2019
Size	11–50 on LinkedIn; ~23–30 staff + ~25-person advisor bench *(self-reported)*	One person	~6 listed; one named principal	Small team; founder-led

	Craig Group	Rick Williams	Quadrillion Partners	Creo today
Buyer	PE sponsors and their $50–350M portcos (LMM)	CEOs/boards of $5–300M private cos; coaches	PE sponsors/portcos and public cos, $200M–3B	PE sponsors, portcos, corporates
Offer	GTM/RevOps strategy + embedded execution	Board seats, CEO advisory, keynotes, workshop, book	Value-creation plans + 8 execution sprints; interim C-suite	Strategy, Growth, Operations, Human Capital
Named method	CG™ Process; Catalyst™, Ignite™, Conduit™	Create the Future® (5 steps)	"Decipher & Deliver"; 8 named sprints; Lunation platform	"Peak Performance"; no named diagnostic
Pricing signal	~$150K typical engagement; performance-based options *(self-reported)*	Not published	Fixed fee per sprint + success fee; "no hourly"	Not published
Proof	~9 case studies, mostly anonymized; 36-logo wall	Endorsements (Joly, McMaster, Edmondson); testimonials	8 anonymized case studies with $ figures; "$1.2–1.4B EV" *(self-reported)*	"10x+ ROI," 15% vs 6% CAGR chart; 3 title-only testimonials
Reach	1.7K company / ~5K founder LinkedIn	"50,000" newsletter readers *(self-reported)*	942 company / ~5K founder LinkedIn	Not captured; founder LinkedIn active
Content cadence	Bursty: ~1.5 posts/mo 2024, sprint early 2026	2–3 newsletter posts/mo; weekly podcast; monthly byline	Weekly blog since Sep 2026 only; 2–4 LinkedIn posts/wk	Insights hub dormant since Nov 2023
Email capture	Unnamed sign-up box	Form on every page (Constant Contact)	Unlabeled form on blog; book early-access	None
Primary CTA	Contact / assessments	Newsletter sign-up; book; speaking	Calendly "Book a working session" on every page	"Contact us" + phone

3 Craig Group ("The Summer Group")

3.1 Snapshot [High confidence]

Craig Group is a Houston-based, technology-enabled sales and marketing advisory firm that works "exclusively with private-equity-backed, lower middle-market companies." Founder Summer Craig came out of HomeAway (through its IPO), Omnicom, Publicis, AT&T, and AOL, and ran a large marketing budget at Gulf States Toyota, the firm's first client. The leadership page lists nine leaders (including partners hired from SBI's PE practice and Consero in 2024–26), about 25 "Go-To-Market Principals" (a bench of fractional advisors), and roughly 11 delivery staff spanning RevOps, paid search, copy, design, and video. Industries: industrial, manufacturing, energy, SaaS, healthcare,

B2B services. The firm is a HubSpot Gold and Google partner, an ACG Houston Silver annual sponsor, and Summer Craig joined the ACG Houston board in September 2025.

Business-model signals *(self-reported)* (from the founder's own podcast interviews): a typical new engagement is about $150K; each partner is expected to land one new client per quarter; gross margin near 70%; customer-acquisition cost near 30% of revenue (which she says she wants to halve); sales cycles of nine months or more because sponsors vet the firm first and then introduce it to portfolio CEOs; and the firm has "engaged about 300 of about 3,000" target PE firms. Early growth was roughly 90% referral.

3.2 Positioning and messaging [High confidence]

- Hero: *"Built for Private Equity. Powered by Results."* / *"Accelerating Revenue Growth for PE-Backed Businesses"* / *"From Growth Stalls To Scalable Growth Strategy."*
- Organizing idea: *"Revenue is a Team Sport"* (marketing, sales, and customer success aligned); *"Impact that Adds Total Enterprise Value"*; *"a tech-savvy extension of your management team"*; *"in months, not years."*
- The founder states publicly that she **dropped the phrase "strategic digital advisory"** because PE investors did not understand it, and re-languaged everything around value creation, enterprise value, and exit multiples. This is the single most transferable messaging lesson in the benchmark set.

3.3 Services and productization [High confidence]

- **Trademarked system.** The CG™ Process (Discover / Launch / Evaluate) maps to three named products: **Catalyst™** (diagnostic and GTM plan), **Ignite™** (ongoing execution and RevOps), and **Conduit™** (analytics; since January 2025 a machine-learning forecasting tool, extended in November 2025 to "board-ready scenario planning, on demand").
- **Deal-cycle-timed offers.** *GTM Due Diligence* (a "rapid 2–3 week sprint" producing red, yellow, or green risk flags and a 100-day plan); *GTM Exit-Readiness Assessment* (6–8 weeks, run 12–18 months before exit, feeding the CIM and equity story); Strategic Growth Alignment; Sales Improvement Training.
- **Delivery model.** Strategy plus embedded execution — the firm builds the CRM/martech stack, runs campaigns, and provides fractional or interim CRO capacity. Pricing is described as "fully transparent" with "options for performance-based structure"; no rate card is published.

3.4 Proof and claims

Self-reported case studies include "doubled revenue" at a named client, a PE-backed equipment-rental company whose leads went from 30 to 120 per month, win rate from 10% to 65%, and job margin from 25% to 43%, and a manufacturer with "ROI up to 20x." A sponsored-style CEOWORLD piece (May 2024) calls the firm a "trusted partner to more than a dozen PE firms" and names AEA Investors, Cyprium, Energize Capital, and Golden Gate Capital. Third-party footprint is limited to ACG sponsor and board listings, a Kayo Conference Series community spotlight (June 2026), and wire-release syndication. **No sponsor appears on a case study, and no metric is independently verified.** Awards are marketing-craft awards (AMA Houston, BMA Houston) rather than PE or consulting recognition.

3.5 Marketing engine by channel [High confidence]

Channel	What they do	Cadence / scale
LinkedIn (company)	Event recaps, articles, hires	1,738 followers; ∼2–3 posts/week when active
LinkedIn (founder)	PE exits, board reporting, event posts; 3 native articles (last July 2024)	∼5K followers; ∼2–3/week incl. reposts
LinkedIn Live	Three episodes, Dec 2024–Jan 2025	Burst, not sustained
Blog	∼80 posts since July 2021 on CRO, customer success, operating-partner topics	∼1.5/month in 2024; 1–2/week in Jan–Feb 2026, then thin
Newsletter	Unnamed HubSpot sign-up ("expert tips, industry trends")	Cadence and archive not visible
Podcasts (guest)	∼9 guest spots Aug 2024–Jan 2025 (Consulting Success, Deal Scout, Into the Corner Office, etc.); no owned show	Heavy late-2024 push; quiet since
Speaking / events	ACG NY Healthcare moderator (Mar 2025), ACG Houston DealFlow panel (Sep 2025), Houston Smart Business Dealmakers (Nov 2025)	∼3–5/year, Texas-heavy
PR	Wire release for every partner hire and product update	∼2–3/year
Lead magnets	The two assessments are the funnel; no gated reports, surveys, or scorecards	None
Outbound	Partner BD quotas; two dedicated BD hires in 2025–26; list of ∼3,000 PE firms	The actual engine

3.6 Strengths and weaknesses

Strengths. (1) A one-line exclusion ("exclusively PE-backed LMM") that makes the firm instantly legible to sponsors. (2) Products named, trademarked, and timed to the deal cycle (diligence → 100-day → exit-readiness) with fixed durations and outputs a deal team can drop into an IC memo. (3) Investor-language discipline. (4) Deep ACG/Kayo embedding plus a repeatable PR habit. (5) The founder as the visible face: podcast guesting, panel moderation, a board seat.

Weaknesses. (1) Small reach and a bursty cadence — quiet for most of 2025, a sprint in early 2026 — nothing like an every-8–12-weeks engine. (2) The newsletter is a bare box with no name, archive, or cadence; no owned podcast, no annual survey or benchmark, no gated asset. (3) Proof is anonymized and self-reported. (4) A Texas/ACG-centric footprint with little Northeast visibility. (5) Scope is sales, marketing, and RevOps only; no pricing, operations, integration, or P&L-wide value creation. Growth remains mostly referral, with CAC the founder herself calls too high.

4 Rick Williams / *Create the Future*

4.1 Snapshot [High confidence]

Rick Williams is a Boston-area solo thought-leadership brand built on one trademarked concept (Create the Future®), one book (*Create the Future: Powerful Decision-Making Tools for Your Company and Yourself*, Amplify Publishing, September 2024), one five-step framework (Define the

challenge / Imagine success / Create options / Evaluate barriers / Choose the future), and a hub-and-spoke content engine. His credibility stack — physicist, Harvard Business School, Arthur D. Little, founder and CEO of a multifamily real-estate company, board chair — is repeated verbatim on every surface. The legal entity, Williams Advisory Partners, LLC, offers "CEO and board advisory services for middle market technology companies" but has no clients, pricing, case studies, or independent press footprint. **His audience is general CEOs, founders, and directors of $5–300M private companies, not PE sponsors.**

4.2 Positioning and messaging [High confidence]

- *"Helping Leaders Succeed." / "Leaders create the future by the decisions they make." / "Create the Future is about how to decide — not what to decide."*
- *"An engaged board of directors is a value accelerator for every company"*; the CEO of a $5–300M company has a "lonely job."
- The framework is pitched as replacing "a $500,000 consulting engagement" — i.e., he positions *against* firms like Creo, selling tools instead of hours.

4.3 What he sells

Board seats (several life-science and fintech directorships, with CEO coaching bundled in); CEO/board advisory under Williams Advisory Partners; two keynotes ("Making Difficult Decisions in a Time of Change" and "Make Your Board of Directors into a Value Accelerator") with a key-takeaways handout; a Create the Future® workshop for leaders "and their coaches and consultants"; and the book ($35 retail, $5 off on his site, Kindle and Audible, a free introductory chapter as the lead magnet, and a bulk-quote option). No fees are published and no speaker-bureau listing was found.

4.4 Content engine by channel [High confidence]

Channel	Mechanics	Cadence / audience evidence
Newsletter	Constant Contact; name/email form on every page; blog archive of ∼150 posts	∼2–3 posts/month through 2026. "50,000 readers" *(self-reported)* — no third-party verification
Bylines	CEOWORLD is the workhorse (28 bylines 2018–Oct 2026, Executive Council member); also Wiley *Board Leadership* (2024, 2026), *Chief Executive*, *Private Company Director*, Forbes India	∼every 4–6 weeks in 2026; blog posts are visibly repurposed into bylines under the same titles
Podcast (owned)	*Create the Future with Rick Williams* — launched ∼Q1 2026; Apple, Spotify, iHeart, YouTube	Weekly (Wednesdays), 28–29 episodes, 37–44 min; guests are small-company CEOs, coaches, nonprofit leaders — no PE sponsors
Podcast (guest)	Marketer of the Day (twice), OnBoards, Everyday MBA, HR for Humans at Work, and others	Roughly monthly "borrowed audience" appearances
Speaking	Heckerling Institute luncheon (Jan 2026), trade associations, HBS alumni board program; speaker sheet, keynote reel, media kit all downloadable	Regional and trade venues; no Vistage/YPO/ACG/NACD found despite the Vistage foreword
LinkedIn / social	Profile exists; Instagram 11 followers and stale; X and Facebook present	Follower count and cadence could not be read; social is clearly secondary

A notable mechanic: his podcast **guest-application form** screens applicants by organization size and revenue and explicitly invites "podcast hosts open to reciprocal guesting" — a deliberate guest-swap growth loop.

4.5 Strengths and weaknesses

Strengths. (1) Ruthless message discipline — one owned, trademarked concept and one phrase set, repeated everywhere. (2) Email-first: capture on every page; the list is the asset, and each piece is written once for the newsletter and then syndicated to blog, CEOWORLD, Wiley, and podcast topics. (3) Pre-packaged, dated sales collateral (speaker sheet, keynote summaries, media kit, free chapter) that lowers friction for bookers. (4) A borrowed-audience loop and relentless citation of high-profile endorsers. (5) Newsjacking (executive pay, board firings) keeps governance content timely.

Weaknesses. (1) A personal brand, not a firm engine: no team, no case studies, no named clients, no service pages. (2) Audience mismatch for Creo — no PE sponsors, operating partners, or portfolio CEOs anywhere in guests, venues, or articles. (3) Reach claims are unaudited and public engagement signals are thin (one Apple rating; three Goodreads ratings). (4) Social channels are neglected, so the newsletter does its work in private with no visible social-proof flywheel. (5) Content is reflective and essayistic rather than outcome-quantified — little a PE diligence lens would score as evidence.

5 Quadrillion Partners

5.1 Snapshot [High confidence]

Quadrillion Partners (legal entity Quadrillion Technology Partners, LLC; founded 2012; Plano, Texas) describes itself as "operator-led performance improvement for PE-backed and public companies" delivering "EBITDA, margin, and working capital gains through execution sprints." The only person named anywhere on the site is founder **George Stelling** (first CIO of NVIDIA; pricing and transformation at ON Semiconductor under TPG; interim FP&A/M&A at Synaptics; Bain and PwC; co-founder of Prophet Equity, 2007–11; Tuck MBA). Directories list about six employees; the team page returns a 404; the "Network" page promises "zero consultants" on success-based compensation but names no members. Stelling also runs three affiliated brands — Lunation (an execution-tracking platform), Brilliant Build (digital-twin simulation), and Silicon Century Capital (an investing vehicle with an empty site). In October 2026 he published *Decipher & Deliver*, whose title doubles as the firm's tagline.

5.2 Positioning and messaging [High confidence]

- *"Decipher & Deliver."* / *"Most plans fail in execution, not strategy. We run both."* / *"Outputs are captured value, not decks."*
- *"Consultancies recommend. QP delivers."* — explicit anti-positioning against McKinsey, Bain, and BCG, against PE operating partners ("surge capacity"), and against interim-staffing firms ("a staffing firm owns the placement, QP owns the result").
- PE page: *"Hit the bridge, protect the return."* / *"90-to-180-day sprints tied to the bridge, not 18-month transformations."* Public-company page: *"The quarter is the unit of trust."*
- LinkedIn headline: *"EBITDA, cash & enterprise value in 90 days."*

5.3 Services and productization [High confidence]

- **Three-phase model:** Plan (co-author the value-creation plan in diligence, first 100 days, or mid-hold; "fixed fee, portable") → Execute (8–12-week sprints with a senior lead and a weekly CEO/CFO cadence) → Realize (measured in EBITDA, margin, working capital, revenue).
- **Eight named sprints**, each with a trigger condition, duration, and outcome range: pricing and margin (8 wks, 200–400 bps), commercial operations (10 wks, 5–15% revenue), digital and AI (12 wks, 15–25% IT cost), operational throughput (10 wks, 15–30%), procurement (12 wks, 8–12%), working capital (8 wks, 10–20%), SG&A (10 wks, 10–20%), finance transformation (8 wks, 30%+ faster close). Interim CTrO/CFO/COO/CIO seats "with decision rights and P&L accountability."
- **Published commercial model:** "Fixed fee per sprint, plus an optional success fee tied to defined KPIs. No hourly billing." Fit is $200M–$3B revenue; the FAQ explicitly declines sub-$50M, pre-revenue, and "diligence-only / pure advisory" work — a public *not-a-fit* list, which is rare for a boutique.

5.4 Proof and claims

Self-reported: "$1.4B+ enterprise value since 2012" on LinkedIn and the book site (the FAQ says $1.2B+); $100M of EBITDA captured in nine months as interim Chief Transformation Officer at

ConvergeOne (the only named client); eight anonymized case studies with dollar figures (e.g., "$77M gross-margin uplift, $400M document-solutions provider"); ten homepage testimonials attributed only by descriptor ("$5B Private Equity Sponsor"). Third-party: one paid PR Newswire release (6 Oct 2026), three book endorsements, 16 LinkedIn recommendations. **No awards, press coverage, or analyst mentions were found.** Several credibility leaks are visible to any careful buyer: the two different enterprise-value totals, sprint lengths stated as both 8–12 weeks and 90–180 days, a duplicated problem statement across two sprint cards, and "Lorem ipsum" placeholder labels on the contact page.

5.5 Marketing engine by channel [High confidence]

Channel	What they do	Cadence / scale
Website	Webflow; three Calendly CTAs (working session, intro call, platform demo) on every page; book pre-order block; thin inner-page SEO	Static
LinkedIn (company)	News-hook commentary (KPMG AI ROI, Deloitte cost survey, Nike cost program) tied back to a QP lesson	942 followers; ∼2/week in launch window, six-week gap before
LinkedIn (founder)	Primary channel; headline "EBITDA, cash & EV in 90 days"	∼5K followers; 3–4 posts/week during launch
Email	Unlabeled form on blog; "early access" form on book microsite; no visible newsletter	List-building only
Blog	Six posts, all 8 Sep–6 Oct 2026, categories mirroring the sprints; posts are book derivatives ending in a pre-order CTA	Weekly, but the blog is seven weeks old
Book	*Decipher & Deliver*, dedicated microsite, endorsements, "schedule a consultation"	One-time launch, Oct 2026
Podcast / speaking	One guest appearance (Digital Transformation Podcast, Sep 2026); a 2023 vendor-conference talk; no ACG/PEI presence	Rare
PR	One wire release via a PR agency, republished on the blog	One-off
Paid / video	None detected; Vimeo channel empty	—

5.6 Strengths and weaknesses

Strengths. (1) Extremely sharp, quotable positioning built on a single contrast (operators vs. consultants), with a book title that doubles as the tagline. (2) A productized catalog: eight named sprints with duration and outcome range, a published fee model, and a public not-a-fit list. (3) Dense quantified proof and a credible founder CV. (4) A textbook thought-leadership *launch stack* on a tiny budget: book → microsite → wire release → podcast → weekly derivative posts → founder LinkedIn amplification, all inside six weeks. (5) Frictionless conversion — a calendar link on every page.

Weaknesses. (1) A single-person firm in practice, with a 404 team page and a nameless

"network." (2) Tiny audiences and no newsletter. (3) A content engine seven weeks old and entirely book-driven; sustainability unproven. (4) Inconsistent numbers and placeholder text that undercut an "operators, not consultants" promise. (5) Brand sprawl across four Stelling-led entities. (6) No upper-funnel nurture — no gated tool, webinar, or benchmark report; the funnel jumps from a LinkedIn post straight to "book a call."

6 Marketing-Engine Scorecard

The scorecard rates each benchmark and Creo's current state on the capabilities the brief asks the team to build. Ratings are qualitative: **3** = a working, sustained capability; **2** = present but partial or bursty; **1** = token presence; **0** = absent. They reflect what is *publicly observable* and are meant to focus effort, not to grade the firms.

Capability	Craig	Williams	QP	Creo	Who sets the bar
One-line, exclusionary positioning	3	2	3	1	Craig / QP
Named, productized offers	3	2	3	0	QP (catalog)
Published commercial model	1	0	3	0	QP
Quantified, attributed proof	2	0	2	1	Nobody — open lane
Named team / bench on site	3	0	0	2	Craig
Email list with capture everywhere	1	3	1	0	Williams
Sustained content cadence (12+ mo.)	1	3	0	0	Williams
Owned podcast / video series	1	3	0	0	Williams
Founder LinkedIn as channel	2	1	3	1	QP
Earned/borrowed audiences (guesting, bylines)	2	3	1	0	Williams
PE-native events (ACG, PEI, op-partner forums)	3	0	0	1	Craig
PR / wire habit	3	1	1	2	Craig (Creo did this 2021–23)
Lead magnet (survey, scorecard, diagnostic)	1	2	1	1	Nobody — open lane
Low-friction CTA (calendar, form)	2	3	3	0	QP / Williams

Reading the scorecard. Each benchmark is strong on a *different* column, and no benchmark is strong on more than about half of them. Two columns are empty across the whole set — **attributed, quantified proof** and a **recurring lead-magnet asset** (survey, benchmark, or diagnostic). Those are the two Creo should own. Creo's own row is mostly zeros and ones today, but it is the only firm of the four with (a) a multi-person named team, (b) a prior record of primary research distributed by wire (the 2022 survey of 250+ executives), and (c) four P&L-wide service lines rather than one function.

7 Implications for Creo: Copy, Avoid, Differentiate

7.1 Copy the mechanics

1. **Name and number the offers (QP, Craig).** Creo's four service lines should read like sprint cards: a trigger ("when the 100-day plan is slipping"), a fixed duration, a named owner, and an outcome range Creo can substantiate. Time them to the deal cycle — diligence, first 100 days, mid-hold, 12–18 months pre-exit — the way Craig Group does, so a deal team knows *when* to call.
2. **Speak investor language everywhere (Craig).** Summer Craig's public lesson — that sponsors did not understand "strategic digital advisory" — applies directly to "peak performance" and "exemplary service." Lead with EBITDA bridge, enterprise value, hold period, and exit multiple.
3. **Publish the commercial model and the not-a-fit list (QP).** A public statement of fee structure and minimum engagement size is a trust signal in a credence-good market and pre-qualifies inbound.
4. **Make the founder the channel (QP, Craig).** Company pages do not carry boutiques; both PE-facing benchmarks run on the founder's personal LinkedIn. Rich Vitaro's pedigree (AlixPartners, Parthenon) is currently under-told on the site and should anchor the LinkedIn voice.
5. **Email-first capture (Williams).** A named newsletter, a sign-up form on every page, and an archive. This is the single mechanism that most directly serves "2,000+ decision makers every 8–12 weeks," because it is the only channel Creo would own outright.
6. **Write once, publish everywhere (Williams).** One cornerstone piece per cycle becomes two or three newsletter issues, a byline (CEOWORLD-style outlets accept practitioner contributors), a LinkedIn series, and a podcast or roundtable topic.
7. **Sequence launches instead of posting ad hoc (QP).** Anchor asset → wire release → guest podcast → weekly derivative posts → founder amplification. Creo ran the first step of this in 2022–23; the benchmark shows what the rest of the chain looks like.
8. **A calendar link on every page (QP, Williams).** Replace "Contact us + phone" with "book a 30-minute working session" and a short form.
9. **PE-native events and a PR habit (Craig).** ACG Boston, PEI Operating Partners Forum, and a wire release for every meaningful hire, survey, or product change.

7.2 Avoid the failure modes

- **Bursty cadence.** Craig Group goes quiet for most of a year; QP's engine is seven weeks old; Creo's own hub has been dormant since November 2023. The brief's 8–12-week rhythm is only a differentiator if it holds for four quarters.
- **Unaudited reach claims.** A headline "50,000 readers" or "$1.4B of enterprise value" without a source is a liability under a PE due-diligence lens. Report list size, open rate, and follower growth as measured.
- **Hero dependence.** Williams and QP are one person each. Creo should put team authors on content, not just the founder.

- **Inconsistent numbers and placeholder copy.** QP's $1.2B/$1.4B and 8–12-week/90–180-day conflicts are exactly what a diligence-trained buyer notices first. One set of numbers, reviewed before publishing.
- **Brand sprawl.** Four Stelling-led brands dilute QP's offer. Keep every Creo asset under one name and one URL.

7.3 Differentiate where none of them can

1. **Team over hero.** A real, named, multi-person bench with bios and attributed testimonials. None of the three can show this.
2. **Attributed proof.** Even two or three case studies with a named sponsor or portfolio CEO on record would exceed the entire benchmark set, which is anonymized end to end. This is a Discovery-meeting ask.
3. **A recurring owned asset.** An annual Creo survey or benchmark (reviving the 2022 motion) and a named diagnostic as the gated lead magnet. QP's only tool lives on a separate site; Craig has none; Williams's is a free book chapter.
4. **P&L-wide scope.** Craig Group is a sales-and-marketing shop; QP excludes "pure advisory"; Williams sells decision tools. Creo can own the full value-creation bridge — strategy, growth, operations, human capital — in one firm.
5. **Boston/Northeast sponsor density.** Both PE-facing benchmarks are Texas-centric. Creo's geography is an asset in a relationship-driven market.

7.4 Mapping to the brief's deliverables

Brief deliverable	What the benchmark contributes
Value proposition & storytelling	Investor-language rewrite (Craig); one contrast line and named method (QP); one owned phrase repeated everywhere (Williams)
Customer segmentation	Deal-stage segmentation (diligence / 100-day / mid-hold / pre-exit) layered on PE vs. corporate; explicit not-a-fit list
Content strategy & calendar	Cornerstone-piece-per-cycle model with write-once/publish-everywhere repurposing; sequenced launches, not ad-hoc posts
Email marketing	Named newsletter, capture on every page, archive, measured list growth — the owned channel behind "2,000+ every 8–12 weeks"
Marketing operations & metrics	Track what the benchmarks do not: list size, open rate, follower growth, sessions booked, cadence adherence
Future capabilities playbook	Founder-as-channel plus team authors; wire-release habit; PE-native event calendar; gated diagnostic as lead magnet

8 What We Could Not Verify

- **Identification.** That "The Summer Group" means Craig Group (see §1.2). The client should confirm.
- **Craig Group.** Newsletter platform and cadence; YouTube statistics; any paid or account-based spend; exact headcount (23, 26, 30, or 45 including the advisor bench, depending on source); whether the logo wall shows clients or team alumni; any revenue.
- **Rick Williams.** LinkedIn follower count and cadence (profile blocked to automated readers); YouTube subscribers; Amazon rank and review count; the April 2026 Navigation Sciences board appointment (no primary source found); the claimed Private Directors Association national board seat (PDA's 2026 board announcement does not list him); the "50,000 readers" figure; speaking fees; any clients of Williams Advisory Partners.
- **Quadrillion Partners.** X follower counts; Vimeo content; Amazon bestseller claim and "398 outlets" syndication; the existence and role of a second partner named in a stale directory listing; whether Silicon Century Capital is active; any client names behind the testimonials.
- **Creo.** We did not capture Creo's own LinkedIn follower counts or posting cadence for this document; the Creo column in §2 and §6 draws on the June 2026 market-analysis baseline and a re-read of the public site on 20 October 2026 (Insights hub unchanged; still no newsletter or lead-capture form).

Sources

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Creo baseline. https://creoadvisorsllc.com/ and https://creoadvisorsllc.com/news-insights (read 20 October 2026); the team's *creo-advisors-market-analysis* (June 2026) for the earlier marketing-footprint findings; the client's *Marketing Project Outline — Fall 2026* for objectives and deliverables.